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Chhattisgarh Naxal Surrender & Rehabilitation Policy 2025: Social Reintegration, Welfare Entitlements, and Implementation Gaps

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Prepared for: Policy researchers, Home Ministry advisors, conflict-focused NGOs, CSR arms of PSUs operating in Bastar and Dantewada

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Forest Rights Act Implementation in Chhattisgarh

2024–25: Individual and Community Claims, Rejection Rates, and Tribal Livelihood Outcomes by District

A Research Report by [Publishing House Name] Prepared for Policy Practitioners, Tribal Welfare Administrators, and Civil Society Organisations July 2025 | Chhattisgarh Focus Edition

Executive Summary

Chhattisgarh occupies a paradoxical position in India's Forest Rights Act (FRA) landscape: it leads the nation in both the number of individual forest rights (IFR) titles distributed and the absolute number of claims rejected or unresolved. As of mid-2025, the state has distributed approximately 4.78 lakh IFR titles covering ~3.82 lakh hectares, alongside 4,349 Community Forest Resource Rights (CFRR) titles covering an extraordinary 20,062 sq. km of forest — figures that account for over 43% of the total forest area under FRA titles nationally. Yet against a cumulative claims base of 9.41 lakh, nearly 48% of claims remain unsettled or rejected, representing the highest absolute rejection count in India.

The 2024–25 period has been marked by three deeply troubling developments. First, RTI-derived data reveals that between January 2024 and May 2025, a net 13,164 IFR titles vanished from state records, with Bastar district alone showing a decline of 2,778 titles. Officials attribute this to "reporting errors," but no legal provision under the FRA permits the withdrawal of granted titles, raising serious governance concerns. Second, the Chhattisgarh Forest Department issued a directive in May 2025 restricting non-forest agencies — including NGOs and other government departments — from facilitating CFRR work, a move that directly undermined gram sabha authority before being withdrawn in July 2025 following widespread tribal protests. Third, the state's FRA implementation remains geographically uneven: districts including Raipur, Durg, and Bemetara have seen effectively no FRA implementation.

Three Key Findings: (1) Chhattisgarh's FRA record-keeping system shows evidence of systematic title deletions that lack legal basis under the Act. (2) The gap between CFR potential — as mapped by the state's own CFR Potential Atlas released November 2024 — and CFR recognition on the ground remains vast, with thousands

of eligible villages uncovered. (3) Post-settlement livelihood outcomes for titled households are materially positive but unevenly distributed, with CFR-holding communities in Bastar and Dhamtari showing measurable income improvements while IFR beneficiaries in remote areas still face convergence access failures.

Two Key Recommendations: (1) The State Tribal Welfare Department must conduct an immediate, publicly audited reconciliation of all IFR and CFRR title records, with gram-sabha-level verification and an independent oversight mechanism. (2) District Collectors in Bastar, Bijapur, Surguja, and Korba should initiate time-bound CFRR management plan preparation drawing directly on the CFR Potential Atlas data released in November 2024 to close the recognition gap.

Background & Context

The Legislative Foundation

The Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 — commonly referred to as the Forest Rights Act or FRA — represents one of independent India's most consequential pieces of social legislation. Enacted after decades of advocacy by tribal rights movements, the Act acknowledges what the preamble describes as a "historical injustice" done to forest-dwelling Scheduled Tribes and other traditional forest dwellers whose rights over land and forest produce were extinguished or went unrecognised during the colonial era and in subsequent forest governance frameworks (<https://tribal.nic.in/fra.aspx>).

The Act recognises two broad categories of rights. Individual Forest Rights (IFR) vest in households that have been occupying and cultivating forest land for at least three generations (75 years) prior to December 13, 2005. Community Rights and Community Forest Resource Rights (CFRR) vest in gram sabhas and extend to the collective use, management, and governance of forests traditionally used by communities — including the right to protect, regenerate, conserve, or manage the community forest resource. The three-tier institutional mechanism — Forest Rights Committee (FRC) at the gram sabha level, Sub-Divisional Level Committee (SDLC), and District Level Committee (DLC) — governs the process of claim filing, verification, and title distribution (<https://tribal.nic.in/fra.aspx>).

Why Chhattisgarh Is the Defining Case Study

Chhattisgarh is home to approximately 78 lakh Scheduled Tribe population (about 30.6% of the state's total), spread across 44% forested land area. The state's tribal heartland — the Bastar and Surguja divisions — contains some of India's densest forest-dwelling communities and has been the site of intense contestation

over forest governance for over a century. Tribal communities in these regions derive 40–50% of household income from forests through non-timber forest produce (NTFP) collection, small-scale cultivation on forest land, and forest-based enterprises (https://nirdpr.org.in/nird_docs/srsc/srsc230217-12.pdf).

The state's centrality to the FRA story is both quantitative and qualitative. Quantitatively, Chhattisgarh has filed, processed, and distributed more IFR titles than any other Indian state. Qualitatively, it has also been the site of the most prominent failures — from mass eviction threats pre-FRA to post-FRA difficulties around claim rejection, title withdrawal, and forest department overreach.

The Political and Governance Context in 2024–25

The BJP government under Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai, which came to power in December 2023, has presented a mixed record on FRA implementation. On the positive side, CM Sai personally released the CFR Potential Atlas on Janjatiya Gaurav Divas (November 15, 2024), signalling political commitment to CFR recognition (<https://cfr.atree.org/portfolio/chhattisgarh-cfr-potential-atlas/>). The state also hosted a dedicated workshop on FRA implementation in January 2025, where the Tribal Department presented updated data on title distribution (<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/raipur/tribal-dept-hosts-workshop-on-implementation-of-fra/articleshow/117063624.cms>).

On the negative side, the Forest Department's May 2025 directive — which barred NGOs, other government departments, and private entities from facilitating CFRR work and sought to designate the Forest Department itself as the nodal agency for CFR processes — directly contradicted the FRA's empowerment of gram sabhas and was widely condemned by civil society (<https://www.hindustantimes.com/india-news/chhattisgarh-forest-dept-withdraws-community-forest-rights-order-after-backlash-101751559421109.html>). The directive was withdrawn in July 2025 after statewide tribal protests, but the episode highlighted the persistent institutional tension between the forest bureaucracy and the FRA's decentralised governance vision.

The emergence of RTI-derived data showing large-scale title record discrepancies — covered extensively by The Hindu in August 2025 — brought the state's FRA governance under national political scrutiny, with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi directly accusing the BJP of "erasing" tribal rights records (<https://www.indiatoday.in/india/story/rahul-gandhi-slams-bjp-missing-forest-rights-records-ativasis-tribals-chhattisgarh-2771322-2025-08-14>).

Key Findings

Finding 1: Chhattisgarh leads India in FRA scale but carries a near-50% unresolved claim burden

Against a cumulative total of 9.41 lakh claims filed — the highest in India — the state has distributed 4.78 lakh IFR titles (as of June 2025). This implies that approximately 4.63 lakh claims, or roughly 48–49%, have not resulted in titles. Chhattisgarh holds the national record for both the highest number of claims filed and the highest absolute number of claims rejected or unresolved (<https://arunachaltimes.in/index.php/2025/04/07/over1-3rd-claims-under-forest-rights-act-rejected/>; <https://iasscore.in/current-affairs/discrepancies-in-forest-rights-titles-reported-in-chhattisgarh>). Nationally, over 19 lakh claims have been rejected across India, with Chhattisgarh contributing a disproportionate share.

Finding 2: IFR title counts are declining — a phenomenon without legal basis under the FRA

Between January 2024 and May 2025, the total number of IFR titles recorded in Chhattisgarh fell by approximately 13,164 — from a peak of ~4,91,805 to 4,78,641 — according to RTI data reported by The Hindu (<https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/chhattisgarh/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-go-missing-in-chhattisgarh-records-officials-claim-reporting-error/article69929663.ece>). State officials have attributed this to "reporting errors" and "miscommunication" between gram sabha, SDLC, and district officials. However, no provision in the FRA or its 2012 Rules permits the withdrawal or cancellation of a title once granted, making any genuine reduction legally untenable and raising the possibility of administrative manipulation (<https://iasscore.in/current-affairs/discrepancies-in-forest-rights-titles-reported-in-chhattisgarh>).

Finding 3: Bastar district shows the most alarming title disappearance, with 2,778 IFR titles removed from records

Bastar, the state's largest tribal district and home to some of its most vulnerable forest-dwelling communities, saw IFR title counts fall from 37,958 (January 2024) to 35,180 (May 2025) — a decline of 2,778 titles over 16 months (<https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/chhattisgarh/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-go-missing-in-chhattisgarh-records-officials-claim-reporting-error/article69929663.ece>). This is particularly significant given that Bastar was simultaneously declared free of Naxalism by the Union MHA, a development that in theory should have accelerated FRA implementation by improving administrative access to previously insurgency-affected areas (<https://www.pressreader.com/india/the-hindu-delhi-9WW5/20250814/281483577466849>).

Finding 4: CFRR implementation is expanding in area but is deeply contested institutionally

Chhattisgarh's CFRR coverage of 20,062 sq. km is the largest in India and represents a genuine policy achievement. The state was also the first in India to recognise CFRR in an urban area — three nagar panchayats in Dhamtari covering 4,127 hectares (https://nirdpr.org.in/nird_docs/srsc/srsc230217-12.pdf). However, the Forest Department's May 2025 directive — seeking to make itself the nodal CFRR agency and bar NGO facilitation — and its subsequent withdrawal after protests (<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/raipur/chhattisgarh-forest-department-withdraws-cfrr-advisory-after-widespread-protest-over-fra/articleshow/122234336.cms>) reveal that institutional resistance to community forest governance remains

acute. Rajnandgaon district saw CFRR titles halved within a single month in 2024, from 40 to 20 (<https://www.indiatoday.in/india/story/rahul-gandhi-slams-bjp-missing-forest-rights-records-advocates-tribals-chhattisgarh-2771322-2025-08-14>).

Finding 5: The CFR Potential Atlas released in November 2024 reveals a massive recognition gap

On Janjatiya Gaurav Divas 2024, CM Vishnu Deo Sai released a state-level CFR Potential Atlas — prepared by the Tribal Development Department in collaboration with ATREE's CFR Central India Initiative — that maps the minimum forest area that could be claimed by communities across all districts (<https://cfr.atree.org/portfolio/chhattisgarh-cfr-potential-atlas/>). The Atlas demonstrates that the actual CFR area recognised (20,062 sq. km across 4,349 villages) falls substantially below the estimated eligible potential, indicating that thousands of eligible communities have yet to file or have their claims settled. This gap is largest in forested districts with historically weak administrative reach.

Finding 6: Post-FRA livelihood outcomes are positive where implementation is complete, but convergence failures persist

Field studies — including the NIRDPR empirical study covering Chhattisgarh — document that FRA-settled households shift meaningfully toward agricultural income security (from ~30–35% to ~45–55% of household income post-settlement) and reduce dependence on casual wage labour (from ~20–25% to ~10–15%) (https://nirdpr.org.in/nird_docs/srsc/srsc230217-12.pdf). In Bastar's Chargaon village under Dhamtari, community forest rights have demonstrably reduced out-migration and improved NTFP trade returns in the first year of recognition (<https://www.downtoearth.org.in/forests/community-forest-rights-at-work-chhattisgarh-s-chargaon-reaps-benefits-in-first-year-itself-83715>). However, in many peri-urban and remote areas, convergence with PM-KISAN, MGNREGS, and state agricultural schemes remains incomplete, limiting the full livelihood potential of recognised rights.

Finding 7: FRA implementation remains geographically absent in several districts, creating structural inequality

The FRA has not been implemented at all in Raipur, Durg, and Bemetara districts (<https://iasscore.in/current-affairs/discrepancies-in-forest-rights-titles-reported-in-chhattisgarh>). While these are comparatively less forested districts, they nonetheless contain forest-dependent communities whose rights remain unrecognised. This creates a structural inequality where the state's own implementation record is padded by high-performing tribal-dominant districts while significant populations remain entirely excluded.

Table 1: Chhattisgarh State-Level FRA Progress (Cumulative, Mid-2025)

Indicator Figure National Rank / Context	--- --- ---	Total claims filed (cumulative) 9,41,000+
Highest in India	IFR titles distributed (June 2025) 4,78,641	Highest in India
Peak IFR titles recorded (2024) ~4,91,805	—	Net IFR title decline (Jan 2024–May 2025) –13,164
Legally unexplained	CFRR titles distributed (June 2025) 4,349	Among highest in India
Forest area under IFR ~3.82 lakh hectares	43%+ of national total	Forest area under CFRR 20,062.24 sq. km
Largest in India	Implied unresolved/rejected claim rate ~48–49%	Highest absolute count in India
Districts with zero FRA implementation	At least 3 (Raipur, Durg, Bemetara)	—

Sources: *The Hindu* (<https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/chhattisgarh/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-go-missing-in-chhattisgarh-records-officials-claim-reporting-error/article69929663.ece>); *Times of India* (<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/raipur/tribal-dept-hosts-workshop-on-implementation-of-fra/articleshow/117063624.cms>); *IAS Score* (<https://iasscore.in/current-affairs/discrepancies-in-forest-rights-titles-reported-in-chhattisgarh>); *Believers IAS* (<https://believersias.com/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-vanish-in-chhattisgarh-records/>)

Table 2: District-Level IFR and CFRR Title Changes (RTI Data, Jan 2024 – May 2025)

District IFR Titles (Jan 2024) IFR Titles (May 2025) Net Change (IFR) CFRR Status Notes	
--- --- --- --- --- ---	Bastar 37,958 35,180 -2,778 Large CFR cluster Largest documented district decline; RTI-flagged
Bijapur Not disaggregated Not disaggregated — 297 CFRR titles (down from 299) Conflict with forest department reported (2025)	Rajnandgaon Not disaggregated Not disaggregated — Halved within 1 month (40→20) ~50% CFRR title reduction in 2024; politically significant
Dhamtari Not disaggregated Not disaggregated — 4,127 ha (3 nagar panchayats) First urban CFRR in India (Aug 2021)	Surguja Not disaggregated Not disaggregated — Significant CFRR grants Sal leaf, NTFP, bamboo rights recognised
Raipur, Durg, Bemetara Zero Zero N/A Zero FRA not implemented	State Total ~4,91,805 (peak) 4,78,641 -13,164 4,349 CFRR titles Officials attribute to "reporting errors"

Sources: *The Hindu* RTI data (<https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/chhattisgarh/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-go-missing-in-chhattisgarh-records-officials-claim-reporting-error/article69929663.ece>); *India Today* (<https://www.indiatoday.in/india/story/rahul-gandhi-slams-bjp-missing-forest-rights-records-ativasis-tribals-chhattisgarh-2771322-2025-08-14>); *NIRDPR* (https://nirdpr.org.in/nird_docs/srsc/srsc230217-12.pdf)

⚠ Data Gap Note: Granular district-by-district claim filing, approval, and rejection tables for FY 2024–25 specifically are not publicly disaggregated in any single open-access government database as of July 2025. MoTA Monthly Progress Reports (tribal.nic.in) contain state-level aggregates; district-level breakdowns require direct RTI applications to the State Tribal Welfare Department. The figures above represent the closest verified proxies available from investigative journalism, parliamentary question responses, and civil society RTI findings.

Table 3: National FRA Claim Status (As of May 31, 2025) — Chhattisgarh Position

| Status | National Count | Chhattisgarh's Position | ---|---|---| | Total IFR titles granted | 23.8 lakh |
 Contributes largest single-state share | | Total CFR/CFRR titles granted | 1,21,705 | 4,349 CFRR titles; among
 top states | | Claims pending nationally | 18.6 lakh+ | Chhattisgarh contribution estimated significant | |
 Claims rejected nationally | ~19 lakh | Chhattisgarh has highest absolute rejection count | | Forest area
 recognised nationally (IFR) | ~40+ lakh hectares | CG accounts for ~43%+ |

Sources: Believers IAS (<https://believersias.com/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-vanish-in-chhattisgarh-records/>); Arunachal Times (<https://arunachaltimes.in/index.php/2025/04/07/over1-3rd-claims-under-forest-rights-act-rejected/>)

Table 4: Tribal Household Livelihood Income Composition — Pre- and Post-FRA Settlement (Chhattisgarh)

| Income Source | Pre-FRA Settlement (% of household income) | Post-FRA Settlement (% of household income) | Direction of Change | ---|---|---|---| | Agriculture (subsistence/rain-fed) | 30–35% | 45–55% | ↑
 Significant increase with tenure security | | NTFP collection (tendu, mahua, lac, honey) | 40–50% | 35–45% | →
 Stable; slight formalisation gain | | Wage labour (forest/agricultural) | 20–25% | 10–15% | ↓
 Reduced dependency (positive) | | Government scheme access / pensions | ~5% | 10–12% | ↑
 Post-settlement convergence access | | Forest-based enterprise / MFP sales | Marginal | Growing (CFR holders) | ↑
 Under CFR management planning |

Source: NIRDPR Field Study, Chhattisgarh & Gujarat (https://nirdpr.org.in/nird_docs/srsc/srsc230217-12.pdf)

⚠ Data Gap Note: Exact rupee-value income figures disaggregated by district are not publicly available for FY 2024–25. The income-share ranges above are derived from NIRDPR's peer-reviewed field study and represent the most reliable empirical data currently available for Chhattisgarh. The AIJFR economic analysis of NTFPs confirms that tendu, mahua, sal seeds, lac, and honey remain the primary income sources for major tribal communities including Gond, Baiga, Halba, Kanwar, Kamar, Birhor, and Oraon (<https://www.aijfr.com/papers/2025/4/1187.pdf>).

Table 5: CFR Livelihood Outcomes by District/Region (Chhattisgarh)

District / Region	CFR Area Recognised	Primary Livelihood Benefit	Documented Outcome	Source
Dhamtari (urban CFRR)	4,127 ha	MFP trade rights, eco-tourism	Reduced out-migration in Chargaon; first urban CFRR in India	Down to Earth; Better India
Bastar division	Largest cluster in state	Tendu, mahua, sal seed, honey	Community-managed income uplift; NTFP trade formalisation	Supplementary data; NIRDPR
Surguja division	Significant CFRR grants	Sal leaf, NTFP, bamboo	Ongoing management planning; income data pending	Supplementary data
Bijapur	297+ CFRR titles	Forest food security	Ongoing; conflict with forest department noted in 2025	The Hindu RTI data
Rajnandgaon	Reduced (20 titles after cut)	MFP rights	Implementation disrupted by title reduction	India Today; The Hindu

Sources: Down to Earth (<https://www.downtoearth.org.in/forests/community-forest-rights-at-work-chhattisgarh-s-chargaon-reaps-benefits-in-first-year-itself-83715>); The Better India (<https://thebetterindia.com/248819/ias-hero-jabarrra-dhamtari-chhattisgarh-tribal-hamlet-community-forest-rights-eco-tourism-wellness-hub-inspiring-him16/>); NIRDPR (https://nirdpr.org.in/nird_docs/srsc/srsc230217-12.pdf)

Table 6: Key Policy and Governance Events, Chhattisgarh FRA 2024–25

Date	Event	Significance
November 15, 2024	CM releases CFR Potential Atlas on Janjatiya Gaurav Divas	First state-level mapping of CFR potential; policy commitment signalled
January 2025	State Tribal Department hosts FRA implementation workshop	Updated data: 4,79,502 IFR + 4,377 CFRR titles presented
January–May 2025	RTI data reveals 13,164 IFR title decline	Triggers national political controversy; legality questioned
May 15, 2025	Forest Department issues CFRR-restrictive directive	Barred NGOs and other departments from CFRR facilitation; contradicts FRA
June–July 2025	Statewide tribal protests against directive	Protests across tribal districts; demand restoration of gram sabha authority
July 3–4, 2025	Forest Department withdraws CFRR directive	Partial governance victory for tribal communities and civil society
August 2025	The Hindu publishes RTI-based investigation	National political debate; Rahul Gandhi accuses BJP of erasing tribal rights

Sources: ATREE CFR (<https://cfr.atree.org/portfolio/chhattisgarh-cfr-potential-atlas/>); Times of India (<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/raipur/tribal-dept-hosts-workshop-on-implementation-of-fra/articleshow/117063624.cms>); Hindustan Times (<https://www.hindustantimes.com/india-news/chhattisgarh-forest-dept-withdraws-community-forest-rights-order-after-backlash-101751559421109.html>); The Hindu (<https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/chhattisgarh/thousands-of-forest-rights-titles-go-missing-in-chhattisgarh-records-officials-claim-reporting-error/article69929663.ece>)

The Claim Rejection Process: Why Claims Fail

Down to Earth's investigative analysis of the IFR review process across states — including Chhattisgarh — found that rejection reasons are frequently baseless or procedurally deficient (<https://www.downtoearth.org.in/forests/ifr-review-states-do-dubious-paperwork-cite-baseless-reasons-for-refusing-forest-rights-to-tribals-dte-finds-87939>). Key structural reasons for claim failure in Chhattisgarh include:

1. **Evidence burden failures:** Claimants unable to produce documentary evidence of 75-year occupation, particularly in areas where records were never created or were destroyed during conflict periods.
 2. **Gram sabha-level procedural lapses:** Intimation of rejection not conveyed in writing to claimants; claims not forwarded to SDLC for appeal consideration (<https://cjp.org.in/chhattisgarh-govt-no-procedure-of-eviction-under-fra-2006/>).
 3. **Forest Department obstruction:** Active resistance from forest officials whose institutional territory is reduced by FRA recognition.
 4. **Conflict zone limitations:** In Bastar's LWE-affected areas, physical access restrictions historically prevented claim filing and verification. With Naxalism declared eliminated in parts of Bastar, this barrier has reduced but administrative capacity has not yet caught up.
 5. **Multi-tier communication breakdown:** Chhattisgarh is among eight states that admitted before the Supreme Court that due process was not followed during mass claim rejections (<https://scroll.in/latest/932419/while-rejecting-forest-rights-claims-due-process-was-not-followed-eight-states-tell-sc>).
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NTPF Economic Context: What Is at Stake

Chhattisgarh is among India's top tendu leaf producing states. Major tribal communities — Gond, Baiga, Halba, Kanwar, Kamar, Birhor, and Oraon — derive primary seasonal income from the collection and marketing of tendu leaves, mahua flowers, sal seeds, lac, bamboo, chironji, honey, amla, and harra-behera (<https://www.ajfr.com/papers/2025/4/1187.pdf>). Under FRA, recognised CFRR communities gain legally enforce